

The Road by John Paul Lama

Ambrosio “Ambo” Tatro was a self-proclaimed social media influencer and an amateur MMA fighter training at a respected MMA gym in Marikina. Ken Vanum was a software developer for an IT company and a karateka for a respected karate dojo in Cainta. The two had never met each other before until one fateful night, when Ambo was driving home after winning his fifth amateur MMA fight and Ken was driving to the hospital with his wife, Teresita, who was about to go into labor. Both were driving fast, Ambo from having drunk a few beers after the fight to celebrate his victory, and Ken from a sense of urgency. At the speed in which they drove, they could not stop their cars in time when they crossed paths at an intersection...

The impact was abrupt and violent, yet somehow, both men suffered only a few cuts and bruises. Upon seeing the minor injuries on himself and the great damage to his car, Ambo angrily got out of his car and stormed toward the other car, which the driver was desperately trying to start.

Coward, Ambo thought. Trying to hit and run, eh? We'll just see about that.

“WHAT IS YOUR PROBLEM?!!! WHY DID YOU CRASH INTO MY CAR?! (ANO BA ANG PROBLEMA MO?!!! BAKIT KA NAMAMANGGA?!)” Ambo shouted as he reached the other car. The driver didn’t answer him, instead he just kept trying to start the car. Angrily, Ambo forced open the damaged car door and pulled out the driver.

“YOU BETTER SLOW YOUR DRIVING, YOU JERK! (IKAW, BAGAL-BAGALAN MO ANG PAGMAMANEHO MO, HA?!)” he shouted as he gripped the driver’s shirt with both hands and pulled him up close. “YOU DON’T KNOW IF THE GUY YOU HIT CAN BEAT YOU DOWN! (BAKA MAMAYA, YUNG MABANGGA MO, KAYA KANG PATUMBAHIN-)”

Ken responded by hitting Ambo with a hiza-ate (knee strike). The attack caught him right in the groin and forced him to release Ken, who immediately tried to get back to the driver’s seat.

Ambo snapped. He grabbed Ken by one arm and threw him down to the pavement. He then rushed toward Ken and threw a three punch-one kick combo. Ken narrowly evaded all three by sliding back, then charged forward to land his own punch combo. Ambo took both punches to the face but didn’t even flinch.

“YOU’RE NOT JUST A COWARD. YOU HAVE A PATHETIC PUNCH!” Ambo shouted as he grabbed Ken by the waist, walked several steps away from Ken’s car, and suplexed him. Even when Ken hit the ground, Ambo didn’t stop there. He quickly transitioned from full mount to an armbar from top position. Ken cried in pain and tried to break free, but Ambo wouldn’t let him. It was because Ambo wouldn’t release the armbar that they both got hit when Ken’s car finally exploded...

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When Ambo woke up, he immediately sensed he was inside the hospital, but not on one of the beds. Then he saw that he was in the emergency room...looking at himself as doctors operated on his burned, injured body. He was confused by the sight until he heard a voice speak to him.

“You’re very lucky, you know.” It was a woman’s voice. He turned around and saw a woman all dressed in white standing there.

“Who are you?” he asked.

“I’m your guardian angel. You can call me Lucia.”

“Guardian angel?” he repeated. “Aren’t you supposed to have wings?”

“Oh...I do, but I’m not supposed to show off. Besides, that’s not what we should be talking about.”

“What should we be talking about?”

“You were in an explosion, Ambo. And the guy you were fighting died in that explosion,” she said in a serious tone.

“Serves him right for driving around like a jerk, thinking he’s better than me.”

“You’re missing the point. He’s dead because of you. Him and his pregnant wife.”

“What?” he asked, stunned.

“You heard me. He and his pregnant wife are dead because of you.”

“That’s not my fault-!” he stammered.

“You were driving fast because you were drunk. He was driving fast because he needed to get his wife to a hospital. You fought him because of your ego; so you could assert your dominance. He fought you to get you out of the way; so he could get his wife and unborn baby to the hospital. It *was* your fault.”

“Are you here to punish me? Take me to hell?” he asked, feigning cynicism to cover his fear.

“If that’s what you choose to do.”

“What do you mean choose?”

“I told you, you were lucky. You didn’t die in the explosion. Your body is still alive even now. That is why you can choose to go to the afterlife now and face eternal punishment or continue living and maybe earn a chance to still go to heaven.”

“Wait. Why do I even have a chance at redemption if I stay alive? Wouldn’t killing that guy and his wife and kid get me straight to hell even if I live?”

“While you’re alive, you can still do something to turn your life around and make the world better.”

“Is that all I need to know about the choice I have to make?”

“Not quite. There is one more catch.”

“Which is?”

“You survived, but your body is a mess. If you choose to live, you will live as a burn victim.”

He frowned. “That’s too much of a punishment.”

“It’s a shot at redemption,” she corrected him. “The real punishment is going to hell. And you don’t even want to know what that is like.”

I can’t imagine hell being much worse, he thought. A few steps away, the doctors operating on him seemed to be panicking.

“Make your choice. The doctors are scrambling to save you. Live or die.”

He thought about it for a few seconds. “Live.”

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When Ambo woke up, he was in agonizing pain. The doctors were all relieved that he could open his eyes, but they were not out of the woods yet. They still operated on him.

As for Ambo himself, he remembered everything he discussed with Lucia: his responsibility for what happened to that guy in the other car and his wife and kid, the choice he had to make, his chance at redemption, what he had to do to get redemption. Even with his body in excruciating pain, his mind knew what to do.

But it was easier said than done.

Time passed after the incident on the road. The first few weeks were the most brutal for him. Not only did he still feel the pain of being burned in that explosion, he also became one of the most hated people on social media for what he “did” to that man and his family. He trended and got a lot of hatred online.

Then there was the trials. He was charged with driving under the influence, one count of battery resulting to serious physical injuries for the man, three counts of reckless imprudence resulting to homicide for the man, his wife, and their baby, who all died in the explosion. With the justice system being as slow as it was in the Philippines, he spent weeks, even months in jail between his court appearances.

The jail conditions were nightmarish. The cells were congested, dimly-lit, dirty, and smelled of human excrement. There were no restrooms, the toilets were in the cells themselves, and privacy was nonexistent, which meant everyone could see, hear, and smell everyone’s business. There were no gadgets, sometimes not even any electricity, so there was nothing much to do except stare at the same spot for hours. At night, people had to sleep on the floor or standing up. Mosquitoes, cockroaches, worms, and rats roamed about freely. The only time they could move around a bit was during meals. The food was cold, leftover food, and they had to eat with their hands from cracked, dirty-looking plates. The guards wouldn’t let the prisoners